

Learning With Music: Top 10 David Bowie Songs [B2]

In oltre cinquant'anni di carriera, il re della metamorfosi ci ha regalato pezzi indimenticabili. Ecco dieci dei suoi migliori brani.

Among the most influential musicians ever, English singer David Bowie was a musical [magpie](#), taking inspiration from a [wide range](#) of genres. His eclectic career [spanned](#) five decades and incorporated everything from folk, glam rock, R&B, disco and pop to drum'n'bass and jazz. He was an avid reader and explored many recurring themes in his lyrics, creating multiple [personas](#). Outer Space was an early motif with his first hit Space Oddity and his alter ego Ziggy Stardust, and later again in 1980's [Ashes to Ashes](#). Bowie's half-brother Terry suffered from schizophrenia and therefore many of Bowie's songs deal with isolation and alienation.

1. SPACE ODDITY (1969)

Bowie's first chart success coincided with the 1969 [Moon landings](#). A psychedelic folk tale of an [ill-fated](#) astronaut, it begins with a countdown while ground control [issues](#) instructions through imperatives, with Major Tom later reporting back in the present continuous. Ground Control to Major TomGround Control to Major TomTake your protein pills and put your helmet onGround Control to Major Tom (ten, nine, eight, seven, six)Commencing countdown, engines on (five, four, three, two)Check ignition and may God's love be with you (one, [lift off](#))

2. THE MAN WHO SOLD THE WORLD (1970)

Ignored on its initial [release](#), this subsequently became one of Bowie's best-known tracks after it was covered by Nirvana in 1993. Defying interpretation the lyrics refer to a cryptic encounter, using relative clauses and the past simple. We passed upon the stairWe spoke of was and whenAlthough I

wasn't thereHe said I was his friendWhich came as some surpriseI spoke into his eyes, "I thought you died aloneA long long time ago"

3. CHANGES (1971)

Stung by the commercial failure of the follow-up to Space Oddity, the opening track of Bowie's next album "Hunky Dory" was a prescient reflection on how he should change direction. It uses the past continuous, informal phrases and intensifiers. Still don't know what I was waitin' forAnd my time was runnin' wildA million dead end streets andEvery time I thought I'd got it madeIt seemed the taste was not so sweet

4. LIFE ON MARS? (1971)

Using the chords of Frank Sinatra's My Way, for which Bowie had unsuccessfully submitted lyrics, this is about a girl's disillusionment with life and its depiction in art. It is mostly in the present simple, with some present continuous and present perfect, and many descriptive adjectives. It's a God-awful small affairTo the girl with the mousy hairBut her mummy is yelling, "No" And her daddy has told her to go

5. STARMAN (1972)

Bowie wrote this song with the express objective of producing a hit, basing the melody of the chorus on Over The Rainbow from the 1939 film The Wizard of Oz. It worked, and his glam rock appearance on BBC's Top of the Pops changed pop music forever. The song, about an extra-terrestrial broadcasting messages of hope over the radio, contrasts the past simple and the past continuous. Didn't know what time it was, the lights were lowI leaned back on my radioSome cat was layin' downsome rock 'n' roll"Lotta soul," he said

6. ZIGGY STARDUST (1972)

Bowie's androgynous alien alter-ego Ziggy Stardust propelled him to superstardom. This eponymous tribute recounts the rock god's fictional rise and fall, using past simple narrative and possessive for the band. Now Ziggy played guitar Jamming good with Weird and Gilly And The Spiders from Mars He played it left hand But made it too far Became the special man Then we were Ziggy's band

7. FAME (1975)

The 1975 album "Young Americans" is a homage to Philadelphia soul, an American East coast precursor of disco. Co-written and recorded with John Lennon, the single Fame deals with the trials and tribulations of success and gave Bowie his first US number one. Fame (fame) makes a man take things over Fame (fame) lets him lose hard to swallow Fame (fame) puts you there where things are hollow Fame (fame)

8. HEROES (1977)

Increasingly isolated while touring and working on a parallel acting career, Bowie sought refuge in drug abuse for several months. Then, in 1976, he moved to Berlin — a still-divided city with guards patrolling the Berlin Wall — to recover. The city's vibrant Krautrock scene inspired a trilogy of critically-acclaimed albums with ambient producer Brian Eno, ranging from brooding electronic instrumentals to art rock and new wave. While recording at the studio, he looked through the window to see his producer Tony Visconti (who was married) kissing a girl, and was inspired to write one of his best-known tracks. Looking at possibilities during strife, it uses the future 'will' and modal 'can'. I, I will be king And you, you will be queen Though nothing will drive them away We can beat them, just for one day We can be heroes, just for one day

9. LET'S DANCE (1983)

The early 1980s was David Bowie's most commercially-successful period, with four number ones in the UK: Ashes To Ashes (1980) revisits Major Tom, last seen floating in Space Oddity (1969); the Queen collaboration Under Pressure (1981) is an improvised studio jam about the difficulties of modern life; Dancing in the Street (1985) is a high-energy duet with Mick Jagger; while Let's Dance (1983), biggest-selling single ever with 10.7 million copies worldwide, is a funky story of a couple dancing under the moonlight.

The [bleak](#) lyrics use the first conditional and the modals 'would' and 'should'.
If you say run, I'll run with you
And if you say hide, we'll hide
Because my love for you would break my heart in two
If you should fall, into my arms and tremble like a flower

10. LAZARUS (2016)

In 1995, Bowie [rejoined](#) Brian Eno for the experimental album "Outside", recounting the fictional investigation of the murder of a fourteen-year-old girl. He followed this with a [foray](#) into the nascent drum'n'bass scene. In 2013, after a decade-long hiatus, and believed to have retired, he surprised the music world on his 66th birthday with the [release](#) of the single Where Are We Now?, a reflective walk through Berlin. His 2016 [swansong](#), "Blackstar", another surprise [release](#), was heavily jazz-infused with lyrics inspired by his impending death, notably on the single Lazarus, which serves as a [haunting farewell](#) and alludes to the biblical figure [raised from the dead](#). He died two days after its [release](#).
Look up here, I'm in heaven
I've got [scars](#) that can't be seen
I've got drama, can't be stolen
Everybody knows me now
Click here and listen to the Spotify playlist of David Bowie's Top 10 Songs. Fergal Kavanagh runs the website www.tuneintoenglish.com, the web's largest free resource for learning English through pop music. Click here and you'll have access to the worksheets for the songs included in this article.

Glossary

- **Moon landings** = sbarchi sulla Luna
- **chords** = accordi
- **yelling** = urlare
- **wide range** = ampia gamma
- **Stung** = pungere, ferire
- **prescient** = lungimirante
- **superstardom** = super celebrità
- **Jamming** = suonare improvvisando
- **trials and tribulations** = sfide e difficoltà
- **hollow** = vuote
- **swansong** = canto del cigno
- **Ashes to Ashes** = polvere alla polvere
- **follow-up** = seguito
- **depiction** = rappresentazione
- **rejoined** = riunirsi
- **farewell** = addio
- **Lotta** = contrazione di 'lot(s) of', un sacco di
- **magpie** = gazza
- **dead end streets** = vicoli ciechi, strade senza uscita
- **I'd got it made** = farcela, avere successo
- **mousy hair** = capelli castano spento
- **personas** = personaggi
- **ill-fated** = sfortunato
- **lift off** = decollare
- **submitted** = presentare
- **broadcasting** = trasmettere
- **strife** = conflitto, lite
- **foray** = incursione
- **haunting** = inquietante
- **Wizard** = mago
- **propelled** = spingere
- **spanned** = abbracciare, coprire
- **leaned back** = appoggiarsi all'indietro

- **take things over** = prendere il controllo
- **brooding** = cupi, malinconici
- **bleak** = cupi, tristi
- **raised from the dead** = resuscitare
- **issues** = emettere, impartire
- **release** = uscita
- **God-awful** = orribile
- **chorus** = ritornello
- **eponymous** = omonimo
- **swallow** = ingoiare
- **scars** = cicatrici